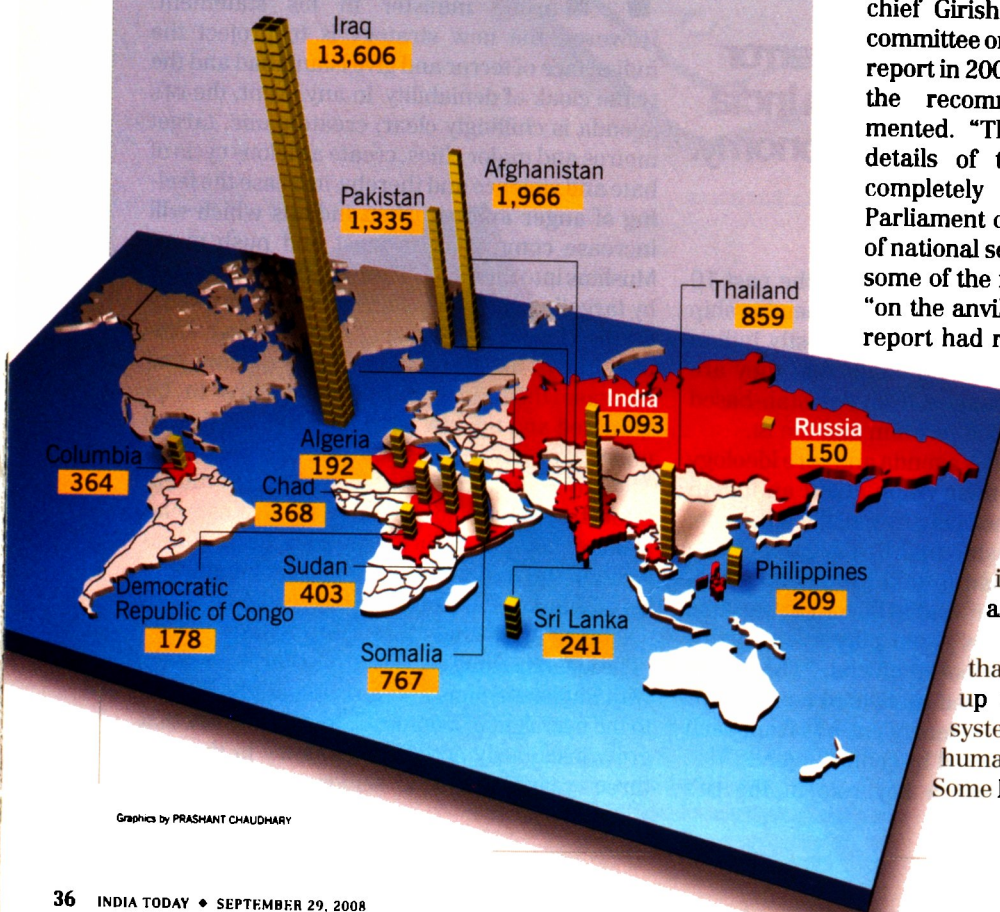


EASY TARGETS

The 2007 Report on Terrorism by the National Counterterrorism Center in the US tracks terror strikes across the world and looks for trends and changes. The report says that "tracking attacks can help us understand some important trends, including the geographic distribution of incidents and information about the perpetrators and their victims." Year-to-year changes in the gross number of attacks across the globe, however, may say something about the international community's effectiveness in preventing these incidents, and thereby reducing the capacity of terrorists to advance their agenda through violence against the innocent.

Approximately 14,000 terrorist attacks occurred in various countries during 2007, resulting in over 22,000 deaths. Compared to 2006, the attacks remained approximately the same in 2007, while deaths rose by 1,800, a 9 per cent increase from the previous year's number. As was the case in the previous two years, the largest number of reported attacks and deaths occurred in Near East and South Asia. These two regions accounted for about 87 per cent of the 355 casualty attacks, each of which killed 10 or more people. As the chart shows, India ranks fourth in the world in terms of the number of terror strikes, after Iraq, Afghanistan and Pakistan.



Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

Intelligence Bureau (IB). "To combat terror," as Director, IB, P.C Haldar pointed out in an ongoing Asia-Pacific Regional Seminar on Terrorism, "traditional counter-terrorism strategies require a quick, dynamic and uniform response conforming to national systems." He said that the paradigm of terrorism has seen a major change with "the terrorist remaining invisible and exhibiting a cross-national spread, spawning intricate networks, with the Internet being used as a force multiplier and a resource base for terror cells."

That dynamism was nowhere in evidence in the Delhi blasts. Instead, there was the all-too-familiar war of words between the IB and the Delhi Police. The former was quick to point to the warning it had conveyed to the Delhi Police as early as on August 31, nearly two weeks before the blasts. The Delhi Police promptly retorted that the UO (Unofficial Order, as all IB reports are referred to) was vague and "not actionable". In the blame game, it became clear that not much has changed in the intelligence-gathering mechanism since the Kargil Review Committee report. The state police forces across the country continue to operate in the same time warp. This translates into ignoring warnings and failing to keep their ears to the ground in sensitive areas. Former Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) chief Girish Chandra Saxena had headed a committee on intelligence reforms which gave its report in 2001. He told INDIA TODAY that several of the recommendations remained unimplemented. "The country may never know the details of the report since it was almost completely omitted while being placed in Parliament on account of secrecy and interests of national security," he said. Implementation of some of the major recommendations remained "on the anvil". Among various things, Saxena's report had recommended that at least 30,000 personnel should be engaged in field duty in the IB. The actual facts are shocking. The total strength of IB is 25,000, of which almost one-third comprise drivers, peons, administrative and secretarial staff. The field strength is 3,500, of which a large number are engaged in political intelligence. A senior IB official said that "more than just men were required to spruce up the intelligence apparatus". The system needs to be upgraded at the human, technical and operational levels. Some Rs 1,000 crore needs to be invested